

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 108

Culture (OWC): [Bambara \(FA08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1946-1949

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Not Specified

Section Title(S): The Name

Bearing a name confers on the bearer the obligation of respecting a taboo (tne or tana). He may neither kill nor, more especially, eat the animal or the plant that represents his name; any infraction of this rule affects his physical and spiritual integrity.

551

Personal Names

On the other hand, relationships commonly known as “joking relationships” are established between families respecting different taboos and bearing different names. One of the characteristic aspects of this kind of alliance is the fact that members of one family are in the habit of carrying out purification rites for members of the other in case a taboo is broken.

551

Personal Names

602

Kin Relationships

Stories relating the origin of family names are well known and there are several versions that have been published for the principal families (1). Some of these bring out not only the history of the head of the family, the first-named, but at the same time the origin of the taboo 75 attached to the name or the origin of the kinship ties observed by the bearers of the name with members of another family.

173

Traditional History

551

Personal Names

In this respect, one of the versions concerning the Kouloubali is most suggestive:

173

Traditional History

551

Personal Names

"The Kouloubali are descended from a family called kuludyu which lived in an underground village in a place called kuluba (literally, big mountain) in Mandé. A famine which lasted for fifty-two years hit the region; the people did not know what to do and ate the leaves of trees in order to survive.

173
Traditional History

551
Personal Names

Two friends, called Konyo (literally, marriage) and Mbadun (literally, I eat), left their homes and set out on a trip to find food. They met three men and decided to join forces with them in order to escape this painful situation. Upon returning to the village, the newcomers, noticing the excrement of a hyena, joked about its white color: "You have only been eating bones," they said. "But no," laughingly answered the other two, "it is hyena excrement." And they asked their new friends their names, adding that they themselves had none. Then together, they tried to make a fire. One night they noticed a flame apparently coming out of the branches of a kapok tree. The tree grew near a rock and the wind, by making  109 its branch rub against the stone, caused sparks which ignited the kapok. They then rubbed two pieces of wood against each other and managed to light a fire which they kept burning for six months. They jealously guarded their secret; men, some of whom still knew nothing of fire and who were in the habit of drying their meat in the sun, came to ask them for burning coals and gave them millet, salt, and domestic animals in exchange. They also gave them their daughters in marriage. One of the men, who belonged to the Diara family, asked them their family names. They answered that they had none. "What does that matter?" he replied. "You will live on a great mountain and take the name of Kouloubali." They then asked the name of their ally (senānku). "We have none," said the new men, "but since this famine we have been living with friends."

173
Traditional History

551
Personal Names

1. See among others L. Tauxier. La Religion bambara, pp. 119ff.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)